

TO EXPLORE THE STRANGE ISLAND OF SAN NICOLAS

An expedition from the University of California will visit the Grenadine Land that is strewn over with skulls and skeletons of a lost race.



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 Race



SAN NICOLAS ISLAND
 LOOKING N.E.



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ISLAND OF SAN NICOLAS



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San Clemente Island is strewn with enormous prehistoric mortars and pestles, and here and there are numerous evidences that a giant race lived there before the Portuguese navigator, Cabrillo, sailed for conquest up the coast of Alta, Cal., in 1542. Santa Catalina is indented by many strange caves, weird grottoes, where one may see remains of a race of fishers and artisans with shells. San Miguel Island has been the scene of titanic erosions by ice, water, and sand. The grotesque pillars that lift themselves above the island level, the winding caves that twist from the shores into the heart of the island, and the roaring gulches and cañons all comprise a spot rich in possibilities for both scientist and dreamer. Santa Cruz Island is used as a pasturage for thousands of sheep, and it, too, is full of absorbing interest regarding extinct races of Aborigines. The Smithsonian Institution scientists have gathered tons of stone, shell, and bone utensils and personal ornaments from Santa Cruz. But San Nicolas Island has by far the most abundant evidences of a tribe of unusually tall and strong people who must have vanished almost in a night. Of all the California archipelagoes this is the most mysterious.

As Desolate as 360 Years Ago.

Notwithstanding the islands—known on the Pacific coast as the Channel Islands—are but from thirty to fifty miles out in the blues of the ocean, they seldom are visited. Every few years an exploring expedition goes to them for a season of scientific study, but

few years an exploring expedition goes to them for a season of scientific study, but, with the exception of Santa Catalina—a famous summer resort for California pleasure-seekers and anglers—a half-dozen visitors do not land at any of the islands once a year. Today the islands remain as lonely and desolate as they did long before the first white face sailed up the coast—300 years ago. The races which occupied these islands are as much of a mystery as ever, and so far science is baffled in inquiring what sort of folk these aboriginal settlers were, how they lived, what they believed, and especially how they so suddenly and completely disappeared from the face of the earth.

The University of California, at Berkeley, is about to begin the most thorough exploration ever made of San Nicolas Island, which lies sixty miles off the coast of Ventura and Santa Barbara Counties.

Skeletons Dot Hillsides.

As far back as the memory of any person in southern California runs hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hillsides of San Nicolas. Strange utensils of serpentine, sandstone, and steatite are found there among the human bones, and the island and its inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension.

In 1835 the Franciscan padre in the Santa Barbara mission, learning that there were but sixteen of the strange and almost extinct Indian race then living there, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over in a sloop and succeeded, as they thought, in getting all on board. At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child, and one of the frequent storms of the



Channel Islands springing up, the sloop was driven away without her. The sloop went on the rocks of Point Conception and all on board was lost.

Sixteen years later Captain George Nidever and two men went from the coast on a sloop to hunt sea otter off San Nicolas. On landing, they were, like Cruseo, astonished to find human footprints in the sand. They saw no one, however, and a storm compelled them to put to sea.

Mystery of Woman's Fate.

It was two years thereafter that the adventurous Captain, revolving in his mind the sight of the footprints in the uncanny island, determined to go and discover and bring over the lonely woman of whom he had vaguely heard. Men accompanied him, and at length they saw on the surf-beaten shore a woman with long, tawny hair, dressed in a queer garb of colored bird skins, and scraping with a bone knife the blubber from a seal.

They surrounded and approached her stealthily, and, although suddenly confronted, she did not appear in the least afraid, but smiled, and then, falling on her knees, prayed to the sun. The wild woman offered no objection when by signs she was made to understand that she was to go with them in the boat.

They reached Santa Barbara, across the rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was Dr. L. S. Shaw, now 80 years old, and yet living there, riding a horse. She had never seen or heard of any object like it, and thought the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterward the last inhabitant of rock-ribbed San

offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterward the last inhabitant of rock-ribbed, tempest-tossed San Nicolas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, furnished by her rescuers, and the curtain fell on her race forever.

Subject of Many Romances.

In speaking of that death at a meeting of the Southern California Medical society the other day Dr. Walter Lindley said that if the woman could have been spared a few years of life a story of one of the strangest races that ever lived in the Southwest, and that had no contamination with the whites, might have been learned. The woman, known as the "Lone Woman of San Nicolas," has been the subject of a score of romances and poems, and food for a lot of philosophy on the Pacific coast for years.

San Nicolas is ten miles long and four miles wide at the widest point. Nothing more desolate than the general appearance of the island can be imagined. As far as the eye can trace there are innumerable circular depressions, showing where primitive dwellings once stood. Not a vestige remains of the materials used in the construction of these rancherías. Hundreds of shell mounds are scattered about, and are found to consist of astonishing numbers of mollusks, the bones of every species of fish found in the channel, skeletons of seals, sea elephants, whales, sea otter, the island fox, and various aquatic birds. Without question these animals were used for food by the tribes that once thronged these boundaries. There are also numerous canine skeletons, several of which indicate a species of bull terrier. Judg-

ing from the immense quantities of dead land mollusks everywhere, there must have been a time when the island supported luxuriant vegetation. Of all this verdure nothing is seen today but a few stunted thorn bushes and now and then a cactus forlornly reaching its grotesque arms out of interminable sweeps of sand.

Many Utensils; Few Weapons.

An examination of some of the mounds discloses all sorts of curious utensils, stone cooking pots, water ollas, mortars, pestles, drills, bone needles, and fishhooks, shell beads, charm stones, pipes, cups, and a few arrow heads, spear points, and swords made of bone. The absence of many weapons proves the peaceful attributes of the islanders. Small imitations of boats and fish carved from crystallized talc and serpentine also show a rudimentary knowledge of the art of sculpture. In many places conical piles of small black pebbles contrast oddly with the white land. In some instances these shells were closely packed in abalone shells. No trace is seen of the "brush pens," in which the lone woman of San Nicolas for years found her only shelter from the cutting wind and sand. Nature, ever unmindful of the individual, long since emerged the superhuman efforts of this courageous life into the universal fate of an entire race. Indeed, every foot of this strange island is eloquent of the extinction of an almost unheard-of people.

At the extreme west end of the island there is a colossal precipice 1,000 feet in height, its chamed and slitted face softened by a luxuriant growth of emerald moss and lichens. The most gruesome of all the sights on this strange island is to be seen on the

lichens. The most gruesome of all the sights on this strange island is to be seen on the broad plateau on the south side of the Chinese camp, at Coral Harbor. Here acres of the naked sand are littered with hundreds of disjointed skeletons and present the most reckless illustration of the "ground plan" of humanity that imagination can picture. Measurements have been made by several scientists of the thigh, leg, and arm bones, and literally bushels of skulls and other parts of the human frame have been brought to Los Angeles from San Nicolas for investigation.

Men of Giant Physique.

The general opinion is that the physiques of the Indian race that swarmed over the island then were much larger than those of any civilized race of today, and that some of them must have been seven feet three inches tall. The skulls of this extinct tribe often measure several inches more than some of the large skulls of today. Many skulls found lying about on the island show that their possessors must have suffered death from a club or blunt battle ax. No one has ever yet found a skull on San Nicolas that shows marks of a bullet. There are many collar bones and shoulder blades, broken and crushed, so that it is evident their owners were slain with some such instrument as a war club or bowlder. Scientists say that the favorite weapon in warfare with the Aleutian savage tribes a century or more ago was a club or bludgeon, and this fact fits with the stray tradition that the Aleutian came down and completely destroyed the people of the Channel Islands about the year 1570.
